The AI Strategy Compass

Do you have an AI strategy, or just a list of tools?

> *73% of mid-market companies have experimented with AI. Only 22% have connected those experiments to a business strategy.*

80% of AI projects fail to deliver value. For every 33 pilots launched, only 4 reach production. Companies without a strategy waste between £200K and £2M across scattered initiatives.

The problem isn't AI. It's that most companies skip the strategy and jump straight to buying tools.

This is the 6-point framework used at the start of every fractional CAIO engagement. It covers the strategic dimensions that separate companies with an AI strategy from companies with a collection of subscriptions.

What you'll get

- → A structured assessment across 6 strategic dimensions
- → A clear gap analysis showing where your strategy breaks down
- → Enough clarity to decide whether to build strategy internally or get help

Time: 60 to 90 minutes with CEO, CTO, and CFO

The 6 Compass Points: Score Your Strategy

Score each dimension 1 to 5 with your leadership team. Be honest: the value is in the accuracy, not the score.

1 = No activity **2** = Aware, no structured approach **3** = Some activity, uncoordinated **4** = Structured, partially implemented **5** = Mature, documented, measured, owned

1. Business Alignment

Score: ___ / 5

- Can we name 2 to 3 specific business outcomes AI should deliver?
- Are AI initiatives connected to revenue, cost, or competitive metrics?
- Does the board understand what AI achieves in business terms?
- Would CEO, CTO, and CFO give the same answer to "what's our AI strategy"?

If you can't finish "AI will help us [measurable outcome] by [date]" you don't have business alignment.

2. Prioritised Roadmap

Score: ___ / 5

- Do we have a documented sequence of AI initiatives?
- Are priorities based on business impact and feasibility, not vendor pressure?
- Is there a timeline with milestones and named owners?
- Do we know what we're deliberately NOT doing yet?

If everything is a priority, nothing is. A real roadmap has 2 to 3 initiatives for the next 6 months, not 10.

3. Governance Framework

Score: ___ / 5

- Do we have a written AI usage policy employees know about?
- Is there a data classification framework?
- Do we have an approved tool list?
- Do we know what AI tools employees are actually using?

If you don't know what AI tools employees are using, you don't have governance.

4. Capability Plan

Score: ___ / 5

- Has the leadership team received AI training?
- Can managers evaluate AI outputs in their domain?
- Is there a plan for building internal AI capability over 12 months?
- Can the team distinguish hype from practical application?

60% of UK businesses cite limited AI skills as their top blocker.

5. Vendor & Technology Assessment

Score: ___ / 5

- Have we independently evaluated needed tools, not just vendor pitches?
- Do we know whether to buy or build for each use case?
- Are vendor decisions made on business fit?
- Do we have exit plans if a vendor doesn't deliver?

Buying vendor solutions succeeds 67% of the time vs 33% for internal builds.

6. Measurement Framework

Score: ___ / 5

- Are success metrics defined before initiatives start?
- Do we measure business outcomes (revenue, cost, time) not AI metrics?
- Is there a regular review cadence?
- Do we kill initiatives that aren't delivering?

If you can't say whether AI investments made or lost money last quarter, you don't have a measurement framework.

Your Score

COMPASS POINT	SCORE
1. Business Alignment	/ 5
2. Prioritised Roadmap	/ 5
3. Governance Framework	/ 5
4. Capability Plan	/ 5
5. Vendor & Technology Assessment	/ 5
6. Measurement Framework	/ 5
TOTAL	**/ 30**

What Your Score Means

24 to 30: You have a strategy. Refine and execute. Focus on scaling what works and closing any remaining gaps.

18 to 23: You have foundations. Gaps in 1 to 2 areas are holding you back. Prioritise the lowest-scoring dimensions.

12 to 17: You have a list of tools, not a strategy. Build strategy before buying more. Structure first, spend second.

6 to 11: Flying blind. This is where most of the £200K to £2M waste happens. AI decisions are being made without direction.

One-Page Strategy Test

If you scored 18+, try filling in these seven statements. If you can't complete them all, the gaps show you where to start.

- **Our top AI priority is:** _____
- **It will deliver:** _____ (measurable outcome)
- **By:** _____ (date)
- **Owned by:** _____ (named person)
- **We'll know it worked when:** _____
- **Our governance covers:** _____
- **We're deliberately NOT doing:** _____

About the Author

Jamie Oarton is a fractional Chief AI Officer through Bramforth AI, helping UK mid-market companies (£20M to £100M revenue) build AI strategies that actually connect to how they make money.

He has advised on AI strategy at the highest levels of UK government, military, and diplomatic services, and has delivered AI training to senior British Army officers.

Jamie works with companies that know AI matters but don't have a plan, building strategy, setting governance, and making sure AI investments deliver measurable results rather than expensive experiments.

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Want to Talk?

If this resource was useful and you'd like to explore whether a fractional CAIO makes sense for your business, the first conversation is always free and no-pressure.

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